



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MIN 676 (M+F) - Amendment 1 - Clarification of Dyslexia Policy: Examination and Assessment Procedures for MCA Written Examinations

Updated 8 November 2024

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Notice to all colleges and training providers, training companies, candidates, and MCA examiners

This notice replaces MIN 435

This MIN expires March 2027

Summary

The MCA is committed to supporting candidates with dyslexia, or other neurodiversity, and promoting inclusivity. An inclusive approach anticipates the varied requirements of examination candidates and ensures they are not disadvantaged. This considers up to date guidance from the Joint Council for Qualifications (JCQ) while maintaining compliance with STCW requirements. This is in line with our public sector equality duty, which is a duty on public authorities to consider or think about how their policies or decisions affect people who are protected under the Equality Act 2010.

1. Introduction

1.1 Making reasonable adjustments for candidates with dyslexia is justified on the basis that the time taken to carry out the activities of reading and writing can be substantially greater for these candidates.

1. 2 This MIN also contains interim guidance for candidates with other neurodiversity, prior to an updated policy following a planned review.

2. Scope

2.1 The MCA written examinations leading to the issue of Certificates of Competency (CoC) are administered by:

- a. The Scottish Qualification Authority (SQA); and
- b. The International Association of Maritime Institutions (IAMl).

2.2 The following policy only applies to examinations delivered by the above, on behalf of the MCA. It does not apply to assessments carried out by Further (FE) or Higher Education (HE) institutions for academic awards such as Higher National Certificate (HNC), Higher National Diploma (HND), Foundation Degrees (FD) and Honours Degrees (HD). These educational institutions will have their own policies which meet the needs of learners with dyslexia or other neurodiversity. They should be found in an educational institution's student handbook, further advice may be sought from a candidate's personal/ course tutor, or equivalent.

3. Specific Learning Difficulties Assessors

3.1 The policy regarding acceptable assessors has been revised in consultation with the British Dyslexia Association (BDA).

4. Initial Action

4.1 If candidates believe they may have dyslexia, there are several tools available on the BDA [website](https://www.bdadyslexia.org.uk/services/assessments) (<https://www.bdadyslexia.org.uk/services/assessments>) that can be used to help give an indication of possible dyslexic difficulties. Please note that these screening tests and checklists cannot provide a diagnosis. Dyslexia can only be formally diagnosed through a Diagnostic Assessment carried out by a certified diagnostic assessor.

4.2 If a candidate requires extra time due to their dyslexia, they will need to present their Diagnostic Assessment Report to their college or training provider.

4.3 If candidates have a dyslexia diagnosis and wish to request additional examination time, their initial action should be to contact their personal/course tutor or, depending on context, their educational institution's examinations team, or equivalent. They will be able to guide the candidate in making the application to SQA or IAMI, as appropriate.

4.4 For the purposes of gaining additional time in MCA written examinations, a diagnostic report will be accepted from the following diagnostic assessors:

- a. A Psychologist specializing in specific learning difficulties (SpLD) registered with the Health Care Practitioners Council (HCPC).
- b. Specialist teacher/assessor with Associate Membership of the BDA (AMBDA) and/or an Assessment Practicing Certificate (APC).

4.5 An assessment can have been carried out at any age. It is no longer required to have been conducted after the age of 16. It must clearly identify dyslexia as an educational need and state that reasonable adjustments be made to support the named individual in undertaking written examinations. However, agreements to allow exam access arrangements can be dependent upon the institution's own examination policy. Candidates need to discuss examination arrangements with their institution's examinations team or equivalent.

5. Examination Concessions

5.1 The MCA will allow a minimum of an extra 15 minutes per hour where a candidate has been diagnosed with dyslexia. This time may be extended based on the recommendation of a diagnostic report. However, this may vary according to an institution's examination policy. Candidates should refer to their institution's examinations team, or equivalent, to have extended extra time considered and for arrangements to be put in place.

5.2 Candidates utilising extra time should be accommodated in a separate examination room, away from the main room, so that they are not disturbed by the main body of candidates departing at the end of the normal examination time. Whilst it is accepted this is not always possible, it is considered best practice and effort should be made to accommodate.

5.3 A diagnostic report may recommend that candidates use computers or have access to readers and scribes. If this is the case, then this should be implemented by the college or training provider as a prescribed reasonable adjustment. With regards to the use of computers, the JCQ access arrangements and reasonable adjustments document (<https://www.jcq.org.uk/exams-office/access-arrangements-and-special-consideration/regulations-and-guidance/>) offers a good overview of how these arrangements can work. Deciding which software options are acceptable and compatible with the formats that the exams come in is crucial to avoid technical/ logistical issues on exam day. Candidate familiarity with the arrangement is paramount - to be well established and effective, training and practice are key. All further reasonable adjustments as described above would be managed by the educational institutions and permission to do so recorded on the administration information provided to invigilators.

5.4 Some groups of examinations must be completed within a three-year period prior to the issue of a Certificate of Competency, no concession is granted in respect of this requirement.

5.5 Some candidates with dyslexia find it helpful to read examination papers through a transparent coloured overlay. Permission for a candidate to do so should be recorded on the administration information provided to invigilators.

6. Administrative Procedures

6.1 All candidates applying for reasonable adjustments for dyslexia pertaining to MCA written exams must notify the exam centre of this at least two weeks' before and provide a copy of their diagnostic report. The diagnostic report is sufficient evidence, and the exam centre conducting

the written exam will accept this as evidence of eligibility for additional time.

6.2 Examination centres putting forward candidates with dyslexia for examination must notify the SQA/ IAMI at least 2 weeks before, together with the supporting documentation. SQA/ IAMI will liaise with the MCA and advise the examination centre of any reasonable adjustments required by named candidates.

6.3 Once a reasonable adjustment has been agreed, it will remain valid for all future examinations without reference to the MCA. There is no expiration date and no requirement for renewal. It is accepted that dyslexia is lifelong, notwithstanding that with good teaching and strategies, attainment levels could change.

7. Examination Results

7.1 Where a candidate has been permitted reasonable adjustments in an examination due to this policy, should they ultimately be unsuccessful in the examination, their dyslexia diagnosis may not then be raised as an issue for special consideration.

8. Reasonable Adjustments for other Neurodiverse Candidates

8.1 Reasonable adjustments for other neurodiverse candidates will be managed on a case-by-case basis.

8.2 The processes detailed in sections 4.2 to 4.5 are applicable for all neurodiverse candidates.

8.3 The processes detailed in sections 5, 6 and 7 are applicable for all neurodiverse candidates.

8.4 Section 5.5 references the use of a transparent coloured overlay. While this may not be an applicable reasonable adjustment for all neurodiverse candidates, the process of recording reasonable adjustments on the administration information provided to invigilators remains applicable, regardless of the adjustment.

9. Useful Addresses

9.1 Below are the organisations that may be useful to candidates, colleges, and employers. Below are their email addresses and a brief description of their mission statements. Included are details of specialist training courses for educators:

a. British Dyslexia Association

<http://www.bdadyslexia.org.uk> (<http://www.bdadyslexia.org.uk>)

The British Dyslexia Association (BDA) is a national charity and the voice of dyslexic people. They aim to influence government and other institutions to promote a dyslexia friendly society that enables dyslexic people of all ages to reach their full potential.

b. The professional association of teachers of students with specific learning difficulties

<http://www.patoss-dyslexia.org> (<http://www.patoss-dyslexia.org>)

Patoss is the professional association of teachers of students with specific learning difficulties, for all those concerned with the teaching and support of pupils with SpLD, for example: dyslexic, dyspraxic, dyscalculic, ADHD.

c. Dyslexia Action

<http://www.dyslexiaaction.org.uk> (<http://www.dyslexiaaction.org.uk>)

Dyslexia Action Training and Professional Development is a training and development group. It is an accredited national training provider of courses designed and delivered to support professionals working with individuals with dyslexia and specific learning difficulties.

d. SpLD Assessment Standards Committee

<http://www.sasc.org.uk> (<http://www.sasc.org.uk>)

The SpLD Assessment Standards Committee [SASC] wishes to encourage a spirit of cooperation and help to forge links with a range of institutions to support and embed good practice. SASC aims to support and advance standards in SpLD assessment, training and practice and encourage improvements in best practice in the assessment of specific learning difficulties. The SpLD Assessment Practising Certificate

underpins these aims. SASC has a responsibility for providing guidance on training and implementation of standards and for overseeing and approving processes of awarding SpLD Assessment Practising Certificates.

More Information

UK Seafarer Services
Maritime and Coastguard Agency,
Bay 2/11
Spring Place,
105 Commercial Road,
Southampton,
SO15 1EG.

e-mail: exams@mcga.gov.uk

Website Address: www.gov.uk/government/organisations/maritime-and-coastguard-agency

General Enquiries: infoline@mcga.gov.uk

Please note that all addresses and telephone numbers are correct at time of publishing.

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